



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Capstone Classical Academy
School Website: <https://capstoneclassical.org/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Classicality Audit: Candeo Schools (AZ)

Website used: <https://candeoschools.com/>

Executive Summary

Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Candeo Schools explicitly frames its program around the classical liberal arts with repeated emphasis on forming wisdom and virtue and on the transcendentals—truth, goodness, and beauty. The site names the trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Latin (grades 4–8), formal logic and rhetoric in middle school, and practices like memorization and recitation in the lower grades. It partners with families and articulates a formative, mission-driven culture. As a public charter, however, it does not ground its philosophy in theology or liturgical life; this limits Element 1 (Religious & Metaphysical) under the six-element framework you provided. Result: strong classical alignment in Purpose/Goal, Curriculum, Pedagogy, and Parents/Community; partial alignment in Faculty and Religious & Metaphysical Foundations. Key pages include statements such as “grow wisdom and virtue for a life well lived” and “pursue truth, beauty, and goodness,” and outline trivium-based study with Latin, logic, rhetoric, history (not “social studies”), and wonder-oriented learning.

Method note: This audit uses the “Six Essential Elements of a Classical School” keyword framework (positive/negative indicators) across six categories, with quantitative keyword counts and coverage estimates before assigning ratings.

CATEGORY 1: RELIGIOUS AND METAPHYSICAL FOUNDATIONS

Criteria probes: transcendental moral realism; grounded in theology; liturgical/communal sacred practices.

- School keywords/phrases found (site):
 - “truth, goodness, and beauty”; “virtue”; “wisdom”; “formation”; “wonder” (multiple instances)
- Match to positive indicators (Six Elements / Lexicon):
 - Positive matches: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; wisdom; wonder (matches “transcendentals” and moral realism set)
 - Not observed: theology/theological integration; worship/chapel/liturgy (as expected for a public charter)
- Negative indicators seen:
 - None (no “values-neutral,” “relativism,” or similar)
- Quantification:
 - Positive hits: +6 (truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, wisdom, wonder)
 - Negative hits: -0

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- Percent positive: 1.00
 - Coverage of the 3 sub□criteria: $1/3 \approx 0.33$ (moral realism present; theology and liturgy absent)
 - Rating: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
 - Justification: Strong moral□realist/transcendental language, but absent theological grounding and liturgical life as required by the full classical model in this framework.

CATEGORY 2: SCHOOL PURPOSE AND GOAL

Criteria probes: virtue/wisdom as aim; formation vs information; transcendentals are real/knowable.

- School keywords/phrases found:
 - “grow wisdom and virtue for a life well lived”; “form hearts and minds”; “pursue truth, beauty, and goodness”; “formative journey”
- Match to positive indicators:
 - Positive: wisdom, virtue, formation, truth, goodness, beauty (all explicitly affirmed)
- Negative indicators seen:
 - None (no emphasis on “college and career ready” or “21st□century skills”-style positioning)
- Quantification:
 - Positive hits: +7
 - Negative hits: -0
 - Percent positive: 1.00
 - Coverage: $3/3 = 1.00$
- Rating: CLASSICAL
 - Justification: Purpose is repeatedly and explicitly defined as the cultivation of wisdom and virtue, grounded in transcendentals, and emphasizing formation.

CATEGORY 3: SCHOOL CURRICULUM

Criteria probes: trivium; history (not just “social studies”); Great Books/Great Conversation; cultivation of wonder.

- School keywords/phrases found:
 - Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and description of each stage; Latin (4–8); formal logic and rhetoric (7–8); history & geography; “Western Civilization and U.S. History”; “Classic Literature”; “wonder”
 - Hillsdale K□12 curriculum access; Core Knowledge content sequence described (content□rich, cumulative)
- Match to positive indicators:
 - Positive: trivium, Latin, logic, rhetoric, history, Western civilization, classic literature, wonder (integration/wonder theme)
 - Partial: “Great Books” phrase not explicit, though “Classic Literature” and “great ideas and stories” are referenced.
- Negative indicators seen:
 - None (“social studies”-framing avoided; no project□based dominance messaging)
- Quantification:
 - Positive hits: +9
 - Negative hits: -0
 - Percent positive: 1.00
 - Coverage: $3/4 = 0.75$ (trivium/history/wonder present; Great Books not explicit by name)
- Rating: CLASSICAL
 - Justification: Strong trivium/Latin/logic/rhetoric and content□rich history; broad alignment with classical curriculum aims.

CATEGORY 4: SCHOOL PEDAGOGY / TEACHING METHODS

Criteria probes: restful/scholé; singing/chanting/recitation in lower grades; wonder; Socratic/seminar/debate in upper grades; rhetoric practice.

- School keywords/phrases found:
 - “memorization, recitation” in grammar years; “recitation, music” K–3; “formal logic, rhetoric” in middle school; “ask good questions”; “order and wonder,” “joyful learning”
- Match to positive indicators:
 - Positive: memorization/recitation; rhetoric; wonder/restfulness language (though “scholé” isn’t named); logic training (discussion implied)
 - Note: The school ends at grade 8; absence of high school Socratic seminars is not penalized per your guidance for K–8 schools.
- Negative indicators seen:
 - Minor signal: repeated use of “rigorous” could trend against restfulness if overemphasized; counted as one weak negative.
- Quantification:
 - Positive hits: +6 (recitation, memorization, music, rhetoric, logic, wonder)
 - Negative hits: -1 (rigorous emphasis as a weak counter-signal to restfulness)
 - Percent positive: 0.86
 - Coverage: $3/4 = 0.75$ (lower-school memory work and middle-school logic/rhetoric present; K–8 exception applied re Socratic seminars)
- Rating: CLASSICAL
 - Justification: Clear evidence of memory work and rhetoric/logic formation with a wonder-forward tone; K–8 profile reasonably classical by your criteria.

CATEGORY 5: SCHOOL FACULTY

Criteria probes: teachers as models/mentors; “living curriculum”; collegiality; portrait/profile of teacher/student.

- School keywords/phrases found:
 - “faculty who care deeply and lead with purpose” (culture of respect/diligence/delight)
- Match to positive indicators:
 - Partial: caring/purpose-led faculty aligns with modeling virtue in spirit; explicit “mentor,” “portrait of a teacher,” “faculty of friends,” or faculty formation is not stated.
- Negative indicators seen:
 - None specific.
- Quantification:
 - Positive hits: +2
 - Negative hits: -0
 - Percent positive: 1.00
 - Coverage: ≈ 0.25 (weak explicit evidence on the targeted faculty ideals)
- Rating: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
 - Justification: Cultural language is good; explicit classical teacher formation/portrait is not articulated on the public pages cited.

CATEGORY 6: SCHOOL PARENTS AND COMMUNITY

Criteria probes: partnership with parents; educating parents; open campus/hospitality.

- School keywords/phrases found:
 - “partnership with families,” “walking alongside parents,” robust Parents section with handbook, calendar, uniform, aftercare, tours (open visit)

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- Match to positive indicators:
 - Positive: parent partnership and hospitality (tours/open visits) are explicit; parent formation/book studies not explicitly listed.
 - Negative indicators seen:
 - None.
 - Quantification:
 - Positive hits: +3
 - Negative hits: -0
 - Percent positive: 1.00
 - Coverage: $2/3 \approx 0.67$
 - Rating: CLASSICAL
 - Justification: Strong partnership posture and openness to parents; could grow in explicit parent formation offerings.
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Aggregate Rating: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Rationale: Strong performance in Purpose/Goal, Curriculum, Pedagogy, and Parents/Community; partial in Faculty; constrained in Religious & Metaphysical due to nontheological, nonliturgical character of a public charter. Using the Six Elements lexicon, the overall language and structure are substantially classical but not fully aligned with the theological and liturgical dimensions of the framework.
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What would move the needle

- Religious & Metaphysical: Within legal constraints for public charters, further articulate (in philosophical/secular terms) objective moral order/natural law foundations that underwrite the school's virtue and transcendentals language; clarify how these norms anchor curricular and disciplinary practices. This would strengthen the metaphysical grounding dimension of the framework.
 - Faculty: Publish a "Portrait of a Teacher" and/or "Portrait of a Graduate," and describe faculty formation (e.g., seminars on classical pedagogy, great books reading for faculty). This directly hits the "teachers as mentors/living curriculum" markers.
 - Curriculum: Publicly list literature by grade and identify primary texts/Great Books used to more clearly signal participation in the Great Conversation.
 - Pedagogy: Name specific practices already implied—e.g., "chanting and singing" in K–3 memory work; "seminar/disputation" elements in grades 7–8—to make the classical pedagogy more legible on the site.
 - Parents & Community: Add parent formation touchpoints (book clubs, talks on classical education, recommended reading lists) to deepen alignment with the parent partnership ideal.
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Evidence highlights (select)

- Mission/purpose and transcendentals: "grow wisdom and virtue... pursue truth, beauty, and goodness... formative journey"
- Trivium/Latin/logic/rhetoric: trivium overview; Latin (4–8); formal logic/rhetoric (7–8)
- History, not social studies; Western Civilization: "Western Civilization and U.S. History"
- Memory work/wonder: "memorization, recitation"; "recitation, music" (K–3); "wonder," "joyful learning"

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- Hillsdale and Core Knowledge (content-rich): Hillsdale K-12 curriculum access; Core Knowledge cumulative/content-specific framework
 - Parents/partnership and tours: “walking alongside parents”; robust Parents portal; tours listed
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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